

HOW TO STORE TEA

Loose-leaf tea should be stored properly as it is vulnerable to light, air, and moisture. Tea's spongelike dry leaves soak up any flavors and aromas they come into contact with, so keep them airtight, cool, and dry.

SHELF LIFE

Even though the tea leaf feels very dry, it contains 3 percent moisture and volatile oils, which are vital to its flavor. These oils will evaporate if the leaves are not stored properly. Green tea has the shortest shelf life at 6–8 months, while oolong lasts 1–2 years. Black tea has the longest shelf life of over 2 years, but if it is flavored or has added spices or fruits, it may degrade more quickly. Follow these guidelines to ensure that your tea stays fresh a little longer.

BUY THIS YEAR'S HARVEST

Always start with fresh tea. If the purchase is this year's harvest, it has a better chance of lasting the full shelf life.

SEAL IT UP

If storing the leaves in a bag, make sure it can be tightly sealed after each use.

KEEP IT AIRTIGHT

Store in an opaque tea caddy made of tin, ceramics, or stainless steel. Making sure the container is airtight will prevent any odors from permeating the leaves.

BUY IN SMALL QUANTITIES

Large amounts of tea will probably be sitting in the cupboard for a long time. Take advantage of sample sizes or "taster packs" as this is the best way to try a new tea without having to dedicate space and storage containers for something you may not like.

KEEP IT COOL

Store in a cool, dry area, ideally a low cupboard, but not in the fridge. It is important to store the leaves away from spices and any source of heat.

CHOOSE FANCY STORAGE

Celebrate your tea by storing it in a special container or tea caddy. If using an antique, check the lining to make sure it is not made of lead.

